> profuse rains; the camels were thus delayed and reached the next stage one day after the carts. Fortunately, the governor had halted because of the rain, and together they continued onwards to Bayana. Two miles before arriving at that destination, one cart wrecked and another became stuck in the river; it was impossible to extricate it and the men had to carry the bales of indigo on their shoulders.[13]

There is every reason to imagine that the travails of terrain and weather that large convoys, such as the one described by Mundy, were part of the pattern of travel of the Ujjayini-bound royal party in the first quarter of the third century BCE.

The route that Ashoka and his retinue took, having long ceased to exist, remains unknown, but we can try and visualize it by exploring the villages and towns of his time that existed along its alignments, as also the itineraries of ancient traders and travellers. The general sweep is clear enough: moving south-west from the middle Gangetic plains, the Kaimurs, which form the eastern scarp of the Vindhyan highlands, will have been ascended. By Himalayan standards these mountains are molehills, the highest point in the entire 1000 km long Vindhyan range being only about 1100 metres. But any forty-day journey at the head of a large travelling contingent more than 2000 years ago will have seemed Himalayan, even to a cosseted emperor in his tent.

Moving from the middle Gangetic plains, the Kaimurs would have been ascended, and here Sasaram's location will have been crucial for the prince's travelling procession to move further west towards the Rewa plateau.[14] From Rewa, the Damoh and Sagar areas would have been traversed to Vidisha, and then onwards towards Ujjayini. Each of the important nodes in this broad alignment, incidentally, was linked in multiple ways and could be accessed through various routes. The research of the archaeologist Dilip Chakrabarti, who made it his professional vocation to travel along ancient routes, highlights this. So, for instance, if Ashoka began his journey from Pataliputra and was headed towards the